Sanghamitra for propagation of Buddhism in the island country. The year 2011 marked the celebration of 2600th anniversary of the enlightenment of Buddha in both India and Sri Lanka.

The major irritants however, in Indo-Sri Lankan relations have been the issue of stateless persons of Indian origin, issue of Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), demand of establishing Indian Ocean as a zone of peace, differences on the issue of NPT and CTBT, declaration of South Asia as a nuclear free zone, issue of trade imbalance between both the countries among others. The major disturbing factor over the years has been the issue of civil war in Sri Lanka and the case of the Sri Lankan Tamils.

Since independence of the island country in 1948, Sri Lanka has got embroiled in ethnic problems between the Sinhalese and the Tamils of Indian origin. Since the very inception, the Tamils have been deprived of basic rights, and successive governments in Colombo have adopted discriminatory policies pertaining to land settlement, citizenship rights, official languages, employment opportunities, inclusive education, political freedom and host of other fundamental rights against the Tamils. Matters came to a head with the enactment of the Official Languages Act of 1956. This Act introduced the 'Sinhala only' language policy. Further, there was a massive disenfranchisement of the Tamil workers following the abolition of the colonial system of contractual labour, followed by simultaneous denial of citizenship to these people. They became the 'stateless' people. The Tamils had often been victims of ethnic clashes taking place in the 1950s, 1970s and 1980s. The rise of Tamil insurgency especially after the armed attack and killing of Tamil prisoners and attacks on Tamils in general during 1983 more or less started civil war in Sri Lanka. The demand for a separate 'Eelam' crystallized. Several Tamil militant organizations like Eelam Revolutionary Organization of Students (EROS), the Tamil Eelam Liberation Organization (TELO) and the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) formed a united front. They also received support from the People Liberation Organization of Tamil Eelam (PLOTE).

It is in this context that India-Lanka relation has to be assessed. India's commitment to the unity and integrity of Sri Lanka was upheld in the Nehru-Kotelewala Pact, 1954 (addressing the problem of